Are there properties?
March 16th, 2004

1 Terminology

'Nominalist' in the literature. Some use 'Nominalism' for the view that there are no *abstract objects*, only *concrete* ones. This is supposed to entail not just that there are no such things as *the property of being red* and *the relation of betweenness*, but also that there are no *mathematical* entities such as numbers and sets.

Others—including Armstrong—use 'Nominalism' for the view that there are no *universals*, only *particulars*. This is supposed to be consistent with the existence of sets. The denial of 'Nominalism' in this sense is called 'Realism', although this term also has many other uses!

What about *properties*? Here the waters are muddied by the fact that there are two very different kinds of putative entity that get called 'properties'. On the one hand, there are things like *the property of being red* or *redness*. On the other hand, there are things like 'the redness of my copy of Armstrong's book', where this is supposed to be something distinct from the redness of *your* copy of Armstrong's book. Some use 'property' in such a way that this latter category of entities would also count as 'properties', although this usage seems odd to me—I'd prefer to call them 'states', or (to use Armstrong's term) 'tropes'.

A Nominalist in the second sense can believe in tropes. Not clear what to say about a Nominalist in the first sense.

2 'Something from nothing' arguments

(1) The moon is round.

(2) Therefore, the moon has the property of being round.

(3) Therefore, there are properties.

Everyone should agree that there is one way of taking this argument on which it is trivially and obviously valid.

Argument for this claim: surely everyone must agree that there is one way of taking the following argument on which it is trivially and obviously valid:

(4) The moon is round.

(5) The earth is round.

(6) Therefore, there are properties common to the moon and the earth.

But any interpretation that's systematic enough to make this come out valid will surely also be able to be able to make the first argument come out valid.

Those who maintain that there aren't any properties must intend this claim in some more 'heavyweight' or 'fundamental' sense, on which the step from 'a is F' to 'a has the property of being F' is not obviously valid. If we want an unambiguous way of asking the question they are answering, we might try something like this:

> Are there *strictly speaking* any properties?
>
> Are there *in the fundamental sense* any properties?
>
> Are properties part of the *ultimate furniture of reality*?

There are philosophers who claim not to understand these questions. They don't see what 'there are no properties' could mean, if not something trivially false (or trivially true). Since Armstrong clearly does think there's a nontrivial issue at stake here, we won't be saying much more about these philosophers. We'll assume we know what we're talking about.

Hence we must beware of the temptation to argue from 'a is F' to 'a has the property of being F' (or from 'a Rs b' to 'a and b stand in the relation of Ring). If we intend the conclusion to be understood in a 'heavyweight' sense, this inference begs the question against anyone who denies that there are properties.

3 Sameness of type

It sometimes happens that two things are *of the same type*. What is it for this to be the case?

A **Realist** can take the notion of sameness of type 'at face value': for x and y to be of the same type is for it to be the case that there is some t such that t is a type and x is 'of' t and y is 'of' t. [Other words for 'is of': 'has', 'exemplifies', 'instantiates']

The Nominalist can't endorse this analysis, unless the Nominalist is prepared to conclude that strictly and fundamentally speaking, it never happens that two things are of the same type.

Well, isn't this just what you'd expect a Nominalist to say? Doesn't 'they are of the same type' entail 'there are types'? Perhaps. But surely there must be *some* way for us to express the facts in question using the 'strict' and 'fundamental' language. For example, we can just say that x *resembles* y. So the question faced by the Nominalist is: what is it for x to resemble y?

A complication: 'a and b are of the same type' is highly *vague* and *context-sensitive*, and 'a resembles b' is even more so. It might be better to fix on some less shifty target, like 'a is of the same word-type as b', or 'a resembles b in some respect or other', or 'a exactly resembles b in all respects'.

Note: a Realist doesn't *have* to endorse the 'face value' analysis of sameness of type. Armstrong, for example, probably doesn't believe that there is (fundamentally speaking) any such thing as a type shared by all instances of the word 'the'. Though there might be such a thing as *negative charge*.

4 Armstrong's presentation of the dispute

Armstrong sets up the dispute between 'the Nominalist' and 'the Realist' in terms which may initially seem to have little to do with the dispute I have been talking about:

> There are those philosophers who hold that when we say truly taht two tokens are of the *same* type, then sameness here should be understood in terms of strict identity. The two different tokens have something strictly identical. . . . One and the same thing, the mass, is a constituent of the two things. Historically, these philosophers are called **Realists** and are said to believe in the reality of universals.
>
> On the other side there are philosophers who think that when we say truly that a number of tokens are all of the same type, then all that we are saying is that the different tokens are nonoverlapping parts of some larger whole or unity. . . . The sameness of the tokens is only loose and popular.

What is this distinction between 'strict' identity and identity in the 'loose and popular sense'? The general idea is that we sometimes say 'a is identical to b' when a isn't *really* identical to b, but only related in some intimate way to b.

Armstrong maintains that the relation in question when we use 'identical' to in a loose and popular way is always a relation of the form 'being parts of the same F'. His main example involves temporal parts: he claims that 'the person whom we saw today' and 'the person whom we saw yesterday' are strictly speaking distinct, but loosely speaking identical, since both are parts of the same larger unity, viz. the person.

— N.B.: this is **not** the view held by most proponents of the doctrine of temporal parts. Most proponents of the doctrine would say that descriptions like 'the person whom we saw today' pick out *people*, four-dimensional spacetime worms.

The views Armstrong attriibtues to both Nominalism and Realism seem to me to be too strong.

> Why does the Nominalist have to analyse '*a* is of the same type as *b*' (or '*a* resembles *b*') in terms of *a* and *b* both being parts of some kind of 'larger whole or unity'? *Prima facie* that seems like just one shape an analysis might take.
>
> As regards Realism, we've already seen one way in which the view attributed by Armstrong may be unnecessarily strong: even Armstong himself doesn't want to posit universals for *all* cases of sameness-of-type.
>
> But even if we set this point aside, there's also the question why Armstrong thinks the Realist needs to hold that universals are *constituents* of the things that instantiate them.
>
> This view seems quite odd in all sorts of ways. It raises questions like: 'Does a simple object like an electron have any *other* constituents besides the universals it instantiates? If not, how can two electrons be distinct, given that they have all the same consituents? If so, what could these mysterious additional constituents be like?'